thames view
YOUR COMMUNITY MAGAZINE
ISSUE 9
OCTOBER 05

JOHN PRESCOTT UNVEILS
HOUSING VISION IN THAMESMEAD



Deputy Prime Minister John Prescott chose Gallions Thames Walk development in Thamesmead as the venue to discuss his housing plans with journalist Jonathan Maitland. Speaking on Trevor McDonald's ITN Newsnight Special on Monday 26th September, Mr Prescott made it clear that he was determined to address the lack of affordable housing facing the southeast.

John Prescott is responsible for driving forward the government's housing agenda and his plans to build many more homes in the southeast are never far from the headlines. His visit to Thames Walk was an opportunity for the Deputy Prime Minister to see for himself how young people and key workers are finally able to get a foot on the property ladder through shared ownership schemes run by housing associations such as Gallions.

DEVELOPMENT
Boiler House and Boxing Club

THAMESMEAD IN BLOOM
The winners and their gardens

ONE TO ONE
Cleaning up with Thames 21

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION



John Prescott was keen to chat to some first-time property owners in Thames Walk and dropped in to meet 26-year old Christian Nichol. Christian is a police officer who until recently was living in rented accommodation and struggling to save enough money for a deposit on his own home. He found out he was eligible to buy property through the government's part buy, part rent initiative and today he owns a 45% share in a two-bedroom apartment with a view over the Thames.

Christian's neighbours Clair Dixon and Paul Dunn only moved into their new home two weeks before and were still unpacking boxes when Mr Prescott arrived at their front door. Their story is similar to many thousands of young couples around the country because until recently both were living at home with their parents unable to afford a home of their own. Now they own a 55% share of a one-bedroom Thames Walk apartment.

AFFORDABLE HOMES

In his television interview Mr Prescott said:

"The real problem with housing is that some 75% of properties are single occupied households. People are living longer and fewer houses are coming on to the market. Young people and families are losing out. Doing something to help that group and make home ownership affordable is my responsibility and my concern."

Shared ownership is a highly popular and flexible way to allow key workers or those on low income to purchase property near where they work or their families. It forms an important part of John Prescott's vision of creating vibrant, sustainable communities where people live, work and socialise.

Gallions Freephone 0800 83 84 81

To date, Gallions has sold 167 homes through the shared ownership scheme and a further 50 homes through the government's Starter Home Initiative. Over the course of the next two years Gallions will provide a further 278 homes for key workers in the Thames Gateway and surrounding areas.



THE GATEWAY TO GROWTH

One of Mr Prescott's top priorities within his housing agenda is to redevelop the entire Thames Gateway region. To date some £446 million have been invested delivering new schools, world class sports facilities, health centres, theatres and improved transport links. It is estimated that this massive regeneration programme will create about 180,000 new jobs. Mr Prescott believes:

"The Gateway offers a huge opportunity to tackle the housing shortage in the south east and set new standards for high quality sustainable developments. We want residents to see improvements in their town centres, their local environment and their life opportunities."

The Thames Gateway is one of the government's four key development regions and is the largest regeneration zone in Western Europe.





THAMES WALK THE FACTS

Thames Walk was built by Barratt homes on brownfield land that had been derelict for a number of years. 91 apartments were built on the banks of the river Thames for sale through a shared ownership scheme. A further 40 homes were built for social rent. By combining government and private funding, Gallions was able to purchase nearly 50% of the Thames Walk development resulting in 131 homes being made available through shared ownership.

Working with Wates

The Wates Community Day is taking place at the Tavy Bridge Project Office at 1pm on Friday 14th October. Gallions are arranging for bird and nesting tables to be placed around Southmere Lake while Wates are seeking a talented young photographer.

For more information please call the Tavy Bridge team on 0208 310 8820.

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editorial

Things are beginning to move over at Tavy Bridge with the construction of a contractors' site compound. It is the first step on the road to transforming the neighbourhood and residents will be pleased to see the beginnings of some building activity. There are also some moves going on over at Gallions Harrow Manor Way offices.

This month, Gallions is opening a second office in Sidcup. Some departments who provide centralised services are re-locating at the beginning of October. All customer-facing teams are staying in Harrow Manor Way and all your day-to-day dealings with Gallions will remain unchanged. Please continue to use your usual contact numbers for any queries or concerns.

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ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾਂ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਚੁਣੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾਂ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਵਾਲੇ ਖ਼ਾਨੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਦੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾਂ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾਂ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾。請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu nầy, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phòng bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

October 05

PUNJABI ☐ **CHINESE** ☐ **VIETNAMESE** ☐

(please tick one)

Name: .....

Address: .....

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Return to: Joy McKee, Translation Requests, Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

News Review

OPERATION SCRAP-IT SWOOPS ON THAMESMEAD

A pick up truck, a large Ford Transit and twenty other vehicles were removed and destroyed during a successful Operation Scrap-it swoop in Thamesmead on 8th September. The main targets of the operation were ten vehicles in a housing estate in Bertrand Way, which had been the cause of complaints by local residents. These vehicles turned out to be untaxed, unregistered and uninsured and were promptly removed. Twelve more vehicles from other parts of Thamesmead were also located and removed. Representatives from Greenwich Council and Gallions Housing Association along with Police and Community Support officers all worked together to ensure the excellent result.

Operation Scrap-it is a London-wide campaign funded by the Government with representatives from each Council working in conjunction with the Police and the general public to remove untaxed and abandoned vehicles on the streets of London. The public can report any vehicles they suspect to be abandoned or untaxed to Operation Scrap-it, who will confirm its status and then remove and safely destroy the vehicle.



There was further success during the September 8 Thamesmead operation, as Greenwich Street Trading Officers also impounded two vehicles for sale in Hutchins Road. They are now part of an ongoing investigation to deal with a network of illegal Street traders in Greenwich. The two impounded vehicles took the total number of vehicles acted upon by Operation Scrap-it to 24.

Boiler House and Boxing Club

Gallions development proposal to build more than 100 affordable homes on the Boiler House and Boxing Club site will go before Greenwich Council's Planning Committee in November. If their submission is successful, work may start in December 2005.



Gallions' development plans for these two historic sites have been designed to ensure that they do not lose their landmark status. Speaking to residents it became clear that the neighbourhood would like to see a circular development that might include the chimneys from the old boiler house building. Initial plans have now been changed to include a 'rotunda' style building for one and two bedroom apartments available through shared ownership. Gallions are also looking at a range of options to ensure that traffic around the new development is controlled.

If you would like more information or would like to comment on the proposals, please telephone Coral Mitchell on 0208 320 3422.

Community Roundup

GRB HOUSING FAIR

The summer may be over and the schools back to work but that didn't stop the fun and games at the Gallions Residents' Board annual housing fair. This year's theme was 'Celebrating Diversity' and more than 1,000 people turned up to enjoy an afternoon of family entertainment. Ali G dropped in for a surprise visit while the day took on a more aristocratic tone with the arrival of Emily Howard of Little Britain's 'I'm a lady' fame. The housing fair also saw the launch of Gallions 'Pride in Thamesmead' Award. Alison Breese, Gallions' Director of Operations presented four local residents with an award in recognition of their long-standing contribution to the local community.

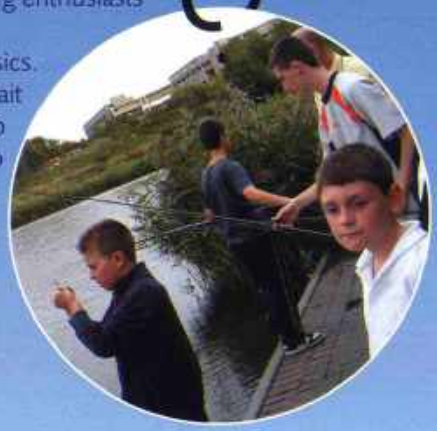


HOOK, LINE AND SINKER

The Neighbourhood Wardens fishing club is up and running and every week new members are taking the bait and signing up. Wendy Mason, Resident Involvement Officer, joined Warden Phil Briggs for an evening of casting off and reeling in.



Behind Thamesmere Leisure Centre a group of 13 fishing enthusiasts gathered one sunny Wednesday evening. Some were complete beginners while others already knew the basics. Together they set up their lines and settled down to wait for the first catch. Eight-year old Daniel was the first to land a catch and although it was his first time at the club he caught a total of three fish within 20 minutes.



Another new member was Mrs Pat Smith who arrived with her grandson Ryan. Although most club members were aged between 8 and 14, Pat very much enjoys the relaxed atmosphere. **"I have fished before and thought that there wasn't a better way to spend the evening than with my grandson fishing. It's a lovely sport, it has tranquillity as well as excitement when you catch a fish".**

If you are interested in joining the Wardens Fishing Club please call Phil on 0208320 3431



CONGRATULATIONS TO SAM AND PAULINE ROBINSON

who are celebrating their golden wedding anniversary on 8th October 2005. Fifty years ago Sam and Pauline tied the knot in Salt Parish Church in Stafford. With parties planned with family and friends in Northern Ireland and England, the couple are set to celebrate in style.

Thamesmead in bloom

A HOST OF WINNERS FOR THAMESMEAD IN BLOOM







BEST GARDENING PARTNERSHIP
MR HADWIN AND MRS MORINA

Every year Gallions throws out a challenge to the community's gardeners and every year they rise to that challenge. The Thamesmead in Bloom competition continues to thrive and once again, the winners have shown determination and imagination. Irene George takes us on a walk through some of Thamesmead's most colourful gardens.

During the summer I get the opportunity to talk to many different residents about their gardens, window boxes and flowering plants. I listen to their stories, learn about their future plans and occasionally can offer some advice. Gardening is a pastime that attracts such a wide variety of personalities. Regardless of the size of their garden the one thing all gardeners have in common is that they are passionate about their subject. It is always a pleasure to spend time chatting with a keen gardener and I always learn something new. Mr Stone for example, has developed a clever way of removing fallen leaves from his slate mulch – he drops it in a bucket of water and scoops off the leaves that float to the top.

One of the most interesting things for me is to see how people adapt their gardening skills to meet their surroundings. People don't need acres of space to use plants and flowers to brighten up their own space. I am always particularly impressed by the generosity of window box gardeners. They put so much effort into making their boxes look attractive mainly for the benefit of others rather than themselves. Passers by and neighbours are rewarded with a spectacular display of colour while the gardener can only see the back of it all from inside.

BEST FRONT GARDEN • MR DAVID SCOTT
Mr Scott's small front garden is entirely planted with especially lovely roses and a really striking hosta.

WINDOW BOX DISPLAY • FIRST PRIZE MRS J COWCHER
The huge variety of plants in this display was a winning feature.

SECOND PRIZE • MR C SNEDDON
Several tiers of window boxes and hanging baskets make a big impression on this first floor balcony.

BACK GARDEN AND BALCONIES

Previously winners have been ordered in 1st, 2nd and third place in these two categories. But there is such a variety of architecture in Thamesmead that it clearly makes no sense to compare a tower block balcony with a spacious private balcony or with a public walkway. Similarly some back gardens are tiny and some much larger. Whatever the size, all gardeners have their own original style. So, in the spirit of celebrating diversity we have selected a whole range of prize-winning spaces.

BEST TINY BACK GARDEN AWARD • MRS T PEETE
A great use of space with only a single bed but pots on the patio and plants on the walls.

GARDEN MOST CRAMMED WITH PLANTS AWARD
MRS P SMITH
Just enough space to walk through the garden to the end with pots even on the roof of the shed and flowers covering the back wall of the house. Oh, and a little hidden water feature among the pots.

BEST USE OF A WALL AWARD • MR AND MRS P KILLICK
Magnificent 8-foot high 'architectural' plants placed against a magnolia-painted wall.

BEST WIND-DEFIANT BALCONY AWARD • MRS KNOWLES
Living on the 9th floor of a tower block does not stop this determined gardener with several tiers of window boxes maximising space.

BEST GARDEN IN SHADE AWARD
MR AND MRS STONE
Shaded by trees on Byron Close from the morning and midday sun, and shaded by the block from the afternoon sun, they have still got a great display of plants to cheer the public walkway.

BEST MINIMALIST BALCONY AWARD
MR AND MRS KILLICK
A hot tropical look in Thamesmead.

BEST TAKE-OVER OF A PUBLIC SPACE AWARD • MRS DAVEY
Running out of space on her own balcony Mrs Davey turned her green fingers to the gardens of Buckwheat Court.

BEST GARDENING PARTNERSHIP AWARD
MR HADWIN AND MRS MORINA
Mr Hadwin, originally from a mining community in Durham and Mr and Mrs Morina recently arrived in Britain from Albania are now in the second year of their successful gardening partnership. Mr Hadwin realised that Mrs Morina was missing her garden in Albania and soon introduced her to the British gardening culture of B&Q and petunias. And while it may not be a Mediterranean olive grove, their walkway is brightened by a mass of white and cream petunias and pots of all sizes adorn the landing.



BEST GARDEN IN SHADE
MR AND MRS STONE

Going Off road with the Archway Project

This summer, a group of young people from Thamesmead were taken 'off roading' as part of a scheme to encourage disadvantaged youths. For three weeks in August, the Archway project ran a summer camp in Wales, where groups of young people who have performed well through the year spent four days 'off roading' with motorcylces. Accompanied by the Bexley police motorcycle team, the group was responsible for cooking their own meals and keeping the camp spick and span. The trip to Wales was a well-earned reward for the young people's hard work on a mechanics training course.



Teaching motorcycle mechanics and motorcycle safety is just one approach the Archway project has of dealing with the variety of issues these young people have to deal with. As part of the Archway Project's aim to break down barriers between young people and police, representatives from Bexley police and probation service joined the group in Wales. The summer camp was also supported by the Bexley Community Safety Partnership and Gallions Housing Association.

Sgt Mark Eley said: **" It was an opportunity to speak to the youths on a personal level and I could begin to see and understand some of the problems they face. I will find this insight invaluable when working within the community at Thamesmead."**

A CHANGE for the better

In April of this year many people saw the last of the traditional order books and cheques through the letter box as the government brought in its new direct payment scheme. Pensioners and those receiving benefits were all encouraged to open a bank account. While many were keen to streamline their payments into one account, others have been reluctant to make the move. Some residents have never had a bank account while others have found themselves in trouble and fallen into overdraft. Helen Chambers, Gallions Banking Adviser believes people are unaware of all the added value a bank account can bring.



She says: **"Many companies now offer customers a discount on their bill if they pay by direct debit. What's more, if you have a bank account you are eligible to access a whole range of financial products. Cheaper home or car insurance are all available to bank account holders."**

Helen points out that all of the bank accounts they set up have no overdraft facility. Gallions is a member of Change, a partnership of 10 Housing associations established to help residents through the new benefits payment system and to advise them of their banking choices.

For more information on how you can set up a bank account please contact Helen Chambers on 07818 424304.

Gallions Freephone 0800 83 84 81

one to one

Talking Thames 21



Thames 21 is a registered charity whose goal is to deliver clean, safe and sustainable waterside environments for all. Tom Broad, Gallions Environmental Services Manager, tells Joy McKee how Gallions has teamed up with the charity to improve Thamesmead's canal and lake network.

Gallions is responsible for some seven kilometres of lakes and canals within Thamesmead and Tom Broad is determined that these waterways get the level of regular maintenance and support they deserve.

"Thamesmead's lakes and canals are a brilliant natural asset and are home to an enormous variety of wildlife. These waterways can play an important part in building a cleaner, brighter and greener environment."

Tom got in touch with Thames 21, a specialist environmental charity operating across Greater London. Thames 21's work is essential, as no statutory organisation is required to remove litter and large debris from waterways.

After some discussion it soon became clear that by working together Gallions and Thames 21 could form a partnership to tackle the challenge of caring for the local lakes and canals. It has been agreed that a dedicated Riverkeeper, jointly funded by Gallions and Thames 21, will be employed to oversee the upkeep of the waterways.

Tom says: "The partnership with Thames 21 will bring rewards to everyone in Thamesmead. The lakes and canals will attract more wildlife bringing even greater environmental diversity. Fish stock will increase and residents will see more and more nesting birds. Everyone is keen to look after the waterways and we are delighted that we have found the best way to do that."

Learning lessons

The Thames 21 project also provides a great opportunity for local residents to become more closely involved in keeping the lakes and canals clear of rubbish and litter. The Riverkeeper will run regular community-led river clean-ups and is looking for local volunteers to lend a hand. All equipment is supplied and volunteers can look forward to learning first-hand about the rich and diverse environment living in and around the canals. The first river clean-up will be held on **Saturday 22nd October at the Hutchins Road canal section from 11am to 2pm** (off Central Way at the rear of Woolwich Polytechnic school.) Anyone interested in helping out should turn up ready for action in old and suitable clothes. Children under the age of 16 must be accompanied by an adult.

Tom believes that Gallions work with Thames 21 will be of particular interest to children and is keen to encourage schools and colleges to participate.

"It is a real hands-on way to teach children about the importance of encouraging wildlife and looking after the environment. We have plans to introduce an 'adopt a canal' programme which will help people learn about being responsible for their own environment."

Working with residents, businesses, community groups, schools and sports clubs Thames 21 and Tom Broad have big plans to clean up Thamesmead's waterways. Why not lend a hand and join the team on 22nd October. It is your environment and you can make a difference. For more information please call the River Keeper Co-ordinator on 07968 805751

WHAT'S COMING UP

MUM'S THE WORD

Areas of Opportunity

The North Bexley Community Mothers Programme has been such a success in Erith that it is now coming to Thamesmead. Supported by Bexley's Areas of Opportunities, the programme uses local mothers to offer informal help and advice to new parents, or those with young children.

Community Mothers are trained volunteers, who build relationships with the families they work with through monthly visits. The Community Mothers offer ideas, support and advice to parents on topics, such as health and parenting. Mums in Erith, who have received support from volunteers, have sung the praises of the programme, highlighting the fact of how important it is just to have someone to talk to. One mum said: *"My Community Mother helped me to feel more confident as a parent and an individual"*

The programme is currently looking for volunteers from Thamesmead to be trained as Community Mothers. If you're interested in becoming involved in the programme, please contact Faye Francis on 020 8303 7777 ex 2825.



LET'S TALK RUBBISH

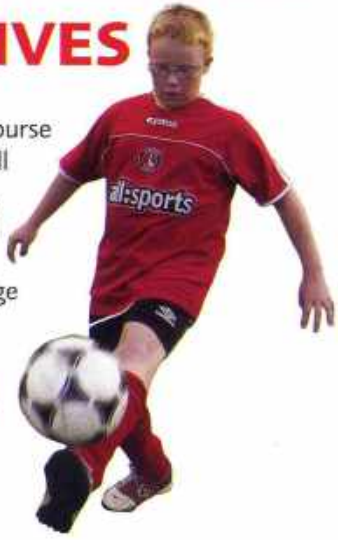
Thamesmead residents are to be invited to join in a pilot waste disposal scheme. Many are unhappy about the problem of dumped rubbish cluttering up the roads and walkways of Thamesmead. Not only is it a health and fire hazard but it means Team Gallions have to spend a lot of time and money clearing up after a few negligent residents. Gallions will be providing free bin bags, highlighting the rubbish chutes and generally encouraging the correct disposal of waste. If the scheme is a success Gallions will be rolling it out across Thamesmead for all their residents. The facts speak for themselves.

- **IT COSTS GALLIONS OVER £400,000 A YEAR TO COLLECT DUMPED RUBBISH**
- **ON AVERAGE THE FIRE BRIGADE ATTEND TO RUBBISH SET ALIGHT 91 TIMES A MONTH.**

FOOTBALL FOR THE UNDER FIVES

Thamesmere Leisure Centre is running a toddler soccer course for 3 to 4 year olds. The sessions will cover basic football skills as well as looking at such issues as co-ordination, balance and social skills. It is also a great way to teach your toddler about teamwork and motivation.
If you think your toddler is ready to tackle the challenge then telephone **0208 311 1119** and book a place.

Book early as spaces are limited.



Dates for your diary

Why not come along to one of our neighbourhood forums and have your say about what's going on in your area.

Monday 10th October

Lesnes, Parkview and Greenmead Forum at The Atrium, 7pm

Friday 14th October

Wates Community Day 1pm Tavy Bridge Project office

Monday 17th October

Broadwater Forum at the Village Hall, 7pm

Thursday 20th October

Southmere Forum at Tavy Bridge Community Hall, 7pm

Thursday 20th October

Waterfield Forum at St. Paul's Church, 7pm

Call Wendy Mason or Martin Hogan on 0800 83 84 81 or email getinvolved@gallionsha.co.uk

RIGHT FIRST TIME REPAIRS

As part of streamlining their service delivery process, Gallions and Axis Europe are moving to a 'Right first time' repair service. Currently residents calling to report a fault log the detail with the customer contact team and a surveyor is sent out to assess what action is necessary. Axis will then dispatch someone to attend to the repair. This right first time approach to repairs replaces the two-step process by sending Axis to effect the repair directly. This will provide a more efficient service to residents and will ensure that the majority of repairs are fixed at "First Visit", rather than having to wait for further instruction from Gallions. Terry Bird, Gallions Head of Assets believes that the introduction of right first time repair service will make a real difference to residents and repair management.

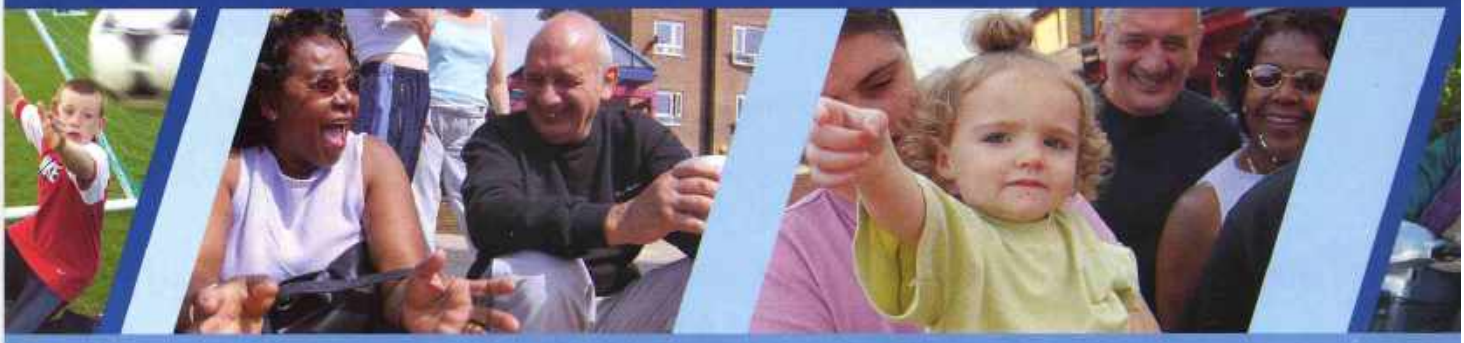


RUBBISH AMNESTY 2005

0800 83 84 81

5TH NOVEMBER 3RD DECEMBER

Gallions Freephone 0800 83 84 81



Gallions Green Team



The Green Team is working hard to control Gallions' impact on the wider environment. Seeking solutions to benefit young and old alike, the Green Team's specialist skills are helping shape an agenda for long-term change.

Today, Gallions is leading the way in building a brighter tomorrow.

- New developments are built to the highest environmental specifications
- Elderly residents are advised about heating homes efficiently
- All residents groups are informed of affordable warmth options
- Polystyrene products containing ozone-depleting gases are prohibited
- Paper is sourced from sustainable forests and recycling encouraged

For more information on how you can take steps to protect the planet please contact the Green Team on 0800 83 84 81

Contact us

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London
SE2 9XH

For all enquiries please contact the
Customer Response Centre
0800 83 84 81
It's a freephone number that you can use to book services, repairs or for any other enquiries.

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION